



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

PEDESTRIANS watch the tide near a lifeguard tower at Thalia Street Beach in Laguna Beach last week.

COLUMN ONE

He took his gang down with him

The viciousness of a Valley crime boss ultimately destroyed most of his following.

By MATTHEW ORMSETH

Zequiel Romo’s gang had plagued Panorama City for decades. Named after Blythe Street — a short thoroughfare flanked by overcrowded apartments — the crew had robbed, stole, peddled drugs and shot up rivals since the 1980s, seemingly untroubled by the city of Los Angeles’ attempts to defeat it.

The city poured millions into fixing blight, lining the street with trees and turning a vacant lot filled with stripped cars into a park. It dispatched extra police patrols, threw up concrete barricades to block roads that functioned as crack cocaine drive-throughs, and obtained an injunction that prohibited Blythe Street members from living in Panorama City.

But the gang endured, and after getting out of prison in 2014, Romo seized control of Blythe Street. In the years that followed, it seems that Romo may have succeeded where the city failed.

Ruthless and suspicious, Romo ordered the deaths of internal rivals, suspected informants and even a young hanger-on who got an unsanctioned tattoo. The aftershocks of his rule are [See Blythe Street, A7]

El Niño could worsen erosion of state’s coast

By RONG-GONG LIN II AND ROBERT GAUTHIER

California’s modern coastline is under assault like never before, and El Niño is poised to make things worse.

Hotter ocean waters are pushing tide lines higher. Powerful Pacific hurricanes are lashing the shoreline with series of strong waves, leaving teetering infrastructure and blotted-out beaches in their wake.

And the forecast for a powerful El Niño this winter is expected to put more pressure on beaches. From Carlsbad to Malibu to Santa Cruz, erosion is already re-making the maps of popular beaches in dramatic ways.

Erosion has gotten so bad along Point Dume Beach in Malibu, for example, that the ocean threatened to collapse a key road essential to access the parking lot.

Churning ocean forces from a distant hurricane just “ate away, I want to say, 50 or 60 feet of sand, and then it got all the way to the roadway,” said Warren Ontiveros, deputy director of the L.A. County Department of Beaches and Harbors, which manages the beach.

Workers have been frantically building an emergency revetment — placing rocks

on the coast to armor the shoreline against the waves — to shore up the roadway, located on a narrow strip of coastline pinched between the ocean and a cliff. It’s the only access point vehicles can reliably take to what locals call Westward Beach.

“The ocean has been taking sand from this area for decades, and so there’s been a shrinking buffer to protect that roadway,” Ontiveros said.

Communities along the coast are facing similar challenges.

“We’re seeing exceptional erosion in those places, and one of the concerning things is that we most likely will have larger waves this winter, and so sections of our coast are going to get that one-two punch,” said Jonathan Warrick, a research geologist with the U.S. Geological Survey.

“It should be concerning to our coastal residents.”

Past winters influenced by “very strong” El Niños — as forecasters say this one is almost certain to be — have battered the California coast.

The previous record-strong El Niño in [See Beaches, A6]

Trump aide grabs public’s eye

Conservative Californian takes her place at his side

By ANA CEBALLOS AND HANNAH FRY

WASHINGTON — Natalie Harp has never been in the spotlight quite like this.

Before the 35-year-old White House aide made headlines for her close access to President Trump, much of her early life was spent in Southern California, where she was homeschooled and attended a megachurch on Sundays — a quiet upbringing that, her brother says, was defined by conservative values and Christian teachings.

Their mother taught them at home using educa-

tional materials written from a biblical worldview. The family would attend services regularly at Shadow Mountain Church in El Cajon, where pastors would deliver sermons like the one from a recent Sunday, calling on God to use its thousands of congregants “in a way that turns this world upside down.”

“We were raised with the idea that America was God’s gift to the world and it’s the only place that people really live in freedom,” Preston Harp, her brother, told The Times.

Years later, in 2019, Harp’s ascent into Trump’s orbit began, when she went on

Fox News to credit a health-care bill Trump signed into law with saving her from a rare form of cancer — a story that later caught the president’s attention.

As that relationship took hold, the California family bubble she’d been raised in was bursting behind the scenes, culminating with her father’s suicide in July 2020.

A month later, Harp emerged on the national stage, introducing herself as a “formerly forgotten American from California” at the Republican National Convention, where she declared her devotion to Trump.

“I wouldn’t be alive if it [See Harp, A5]

Personalized pricing under a microscope

State lawmakers seek to stop firms from setting charges based on customers’ data.

By AUDREY MCGLINCHY

In 2025, a New York resident filed a lawsuit against JetBlue Airlines.

The lawsuit included a screenshot of a tweet from X. In it, a user complained to JetBlue that they were trying to “make it to a funeral” but that flight prices had risen \$230 in just one day. A JetBlue representative replied to the tweet, recommending that the customer clear their browser history and try again.

The assumption, the lawsuit alleged, was that JetBlue was using customers’ personal data — anything from income to recent search history — to set prices, based on factors such as their wealth, frugal or profligate spending habits, signs they might have a desperate need for the ticket. The practice is commonly called surveillance pricing or personalized pricing. JetBlue denied using it. Lawmakers and regula-

tors, both at the state and federal levels, have taken note. Amid a growing concern over how corporations set their prices, California lawmakers are debating a bill that would ban surveillance pricing.

But while some pricing experts are cheering on these bans, others think lawmakers are too quick to restrict a practice they say could actually lead to lower prices for consumers.

The backers of Assembly Bill 2564 were enthusiastic about its chances for passage, though the legislative year will come to an end Monday at midnight. The Assembly approved a version of the bill in May, and the state Senate was set to consider it Sunday. If passed, as backers hoped, it would return to the Assembly with still a full day for another vote.

Personalized pricing has been going on for centuries. For thousands of years, a seller at a market might have used visual and social cues — what a customer was wearing, what the seller knew about their family — to quote a price.

“The seller sized you up and thought you were wear- [See Pricing, A6]

Google courting studios for its AI

The technology giant has been talking with executives as it tries to make it in Hollywood.

By WENDY LEE

Tech giant Google has been quietly making overtures to the major studios as it tries to find ways to entice Hollywood to use its artificial intelligence technology.

Google executives have approached representatives at Disney, Universal, Warner Bros. Discovery and other studios about licensing intellectual property to be used in AI models, according to three people familiar with the conversations who were not authorized to speak publicly about them.

Nonetheless, no agreements have been reached yet, partly because of the complexities of the issues surrounding AI, as well as sensitivities around how

Hollywood talent and unions would react, the sources said.

“In order for Google’s tools and technology to be truly usable for large-scale film and TV productions, let alone cinematic exhibition, it is essential that their models be fine-tuned with highly dynamic content and metadata that only Hollywood studios have,” said an insider who was not authorized to comment because of the sensitive nature of the discussions.

The conversations underscore how much both sides have at stake. Google is facing considerable competition in AI from rivals. For their part, studios are under pressure to cut costs and find ways to use AI in film and TV production, while also preventing unauthorized use of their intellectual property.

“Google’s enlisting some of the smartest people in Hollywood to try to unpack [See Google, A10]

In France, shades of California’s fire zones

Climate change has brought infernos that scorched wildlands, homes



WAYAN BARRE For The Times

A HUNTING lodge sits beside a burned pine forest in Le Porge, France.

By MICHAEL FINNEGAN AND NOAH HAGGERTY

LE PORGE, France — A monster fire-induced thundercloud towered over Bordeaux this summer, the first time firefighters had ever seen this type of ominous smoke-and-lightning weather system in France.

The wildfire that produced it drove more than 200,000 people to evacuate in July and tore through 162 square miles of dense pine forest on the Atlantic coast.

It burned down 183 homes here in Le Porge, a tiny town in the middle of the forest where loggers live alongside neighbors who commute to Bordeaux.

One of the houses belonged to Jean-Charles Dine, who works on jet robotics near the Bordeaux Airport.

“Nothing left at all — everything burned,” he said outside the village [See France, A3]



WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times

AARON DONALD UNRETIRES

Three-time NFL defensive player of the year announces his return to the Rams, considered to be among the Super Bowl favorites. **SPORTS, D1**

U.S. hits Iranian rocket launchers

Attack breaks a lull in fighting during an intermittent war that has lasted more than six months. **WORLD, A2**

Weather

Some sun. L.A. Basin: 86/65. **B5**

Opinion Voices **A11**
Obituaries **B6**

Major debut for rising conductor

Anna Handler makes a post-Dudamel launch with the L.A. Phil. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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